10 for the RGP. Big brother isn't particularly chuffed with the rump 30 seats. The trends from 2022, says the party veteran, shouldn't be the basis for present and future calculations.

But the GFP is quite at home with the idea of GOA itself. "There's a feeling that all must come together to defeat the BJP," says GFP chief and former deputy chief minister Vijai Sardesai. He defends his move to induct Fernandes, sweetening that by promising he wouldn't be fielded in the ZP polls. "He has been inducted to help our candidate win," Sardesai says. The GFP, he insists, is "not a platform for defectors".

Takeaways

- **Cong. wants Goa Forward Party (GFP), Revolutionary Goans Party (RGP) in alliance**
- **GFP game, but queers pitch by taking in Cong. turncoats. RGP, too, being wooed by AAP**
- **Upcoming North, South Goa zilla panchayat polls will signal viability for 2027 state poll**

Even the RGP has taken umbrage to the reshoring of defectors. But the instability is echoed on its side too. The RGP is getting feelers from a different firm: AAP. "We share our roots, we're politically compatible," says AAP MLA Venzy Viegas. The two-MLA party has declared 29 ZP candidates so far, banking on goodwill from its developmental works, like installing solar panels on religious structures, healthcare through Amche Arogya Clinics, and rainwater harvesting in diocesan schools. The Congress has stirred the pot further by declaring some of its seats, which has made the RGP and GFP see red.

But the Congress's biggest hurdle lies across this steeplechase. BJP Goa president Damodar 'Damu' Naik says they will take on the Opposition regardless of whatever shape it takes. ■



THE ROAD BACK Bangladeshi nationals at the Hakimpur checkpost in West Bengal

▶ WEST BENGAL

MATUAS GET THE MIGRANT BLUES

Poor Bangladeshis line up to leave, but SIR also stokes citizenship fears among Hindu refugees. Mamata targets the Matuas, a core BJP vote bank

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**

ON THE RIVER-RIDDEN BORDER of North 24 Parganas, two conflicting visuals are juxtaposed. At Hakimpur checkpost, under Basirhat subdivision, groups of Bangladeshi nationals who had entered India illegally are lined up, desperate to exit. Just 35 km away, in Bongaon, thousands of Hindu refugees—dominated by the Matuas—are on the streets. The object of their ire: the same bureaucratic behemoth that has sparked the first phenomenon as it rumbles across poll-bound West Bengal. Clearly, the ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls is producing both predictable and deeply contrary effects.

Kajal Das, a small-time Awami League activist in his